



The Rosemary Branch

Spring 2014



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Grief and Relationships

In many ways, the sustained love and support of family and friends can be very helpful following the loss of a loved one. Grief, however, can also cause great strain on relationships.

Relationships can include (but are not limited to):

- Partners
- Family (parents, siblings, children)
- Extended family (e.g. in-laws)
- Friends
- Work colleagues.

There are many issues that we can encounter in our relationships following the loss of someone close, including hurt feelings, arguments, guilt, blaming and shaming, misunderstandings, lack of understanding, intimacy issues and conflicting grieving styles. “Relationships can be hard work at the best of times,” says Anita Hoare, Regional Specialist Bereavement

Counsellor at the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement, “but when additional pressure such as the loss of a loved one comes in to play, it can cause extra strain on even the strongest of relationships.”

With time, grief can strengthen a relationship, however for others it can cause deterioration, particularly when there is lack of communication and understanding. “The good news, however,” says Anita, “is that many relationships, over time, can and will survive the impact of grief.”

Different Ways of Grieving

Grief is very individual. Indeed, there are a range of factors that can influence the way we grieve, such as culture, gender, age, relationship to the deceased, personal experience, religion and belief systems. It is quite common for two people in a

relationship or for members of the same family to grieve very differently, and this can sometimes cause resentment or misunderstandings. Indeed, our ‘style’ of grieving can often clash with or be misinterpreted by others.

For example, some people are more ‘intuitive’ grievers, experiencing grief in a more outwardly emotional way e.g. by crying, becoming angry, or needing to talk about how they are feeling. Intuitive grievers tend to need emotional and physical support from those around them and are more likely to seek out help from books, counselling or support groups.

Some people however, are more ‘instrumental’ grievers, i.e. they tend to be more private with their grief. They may express their grief by keeping busy and through ‘doing’ e.g. working on projects, creating



memorials, performing rituals, writing in a journal, lobbying for change or fundraising for a cause. Instrumental grievers may compartmentalise their grief, only acknowledging it or releasing it at certain times — often when they are alone. Instrumental grievers are often misunderstood as ‘not grieving’, especially by people who are more intuitive grievers.

Other people find that they are a combination of intuitive and instrumental, or that they grieve intuitively early on, but instrumentally over time. Regardless of the way you, or those around you grieve, it is important to remember that grief is a highly personal and individual experience. Everyone is different and as long as you are not causing harm to yourself or those around you, there are no ‘right’ or ‘wrong’ ways to grieve. Try to respect each other’s way of grieving, even if you don’t necessarily relate to it or understand it.

Grief and Intimacy

Grief can affect the desire for sex and intimacy. For some, grief can cause a decrease in desire for sex and/or intimacy, whereas for others it can create an increased desire. “Sometimes with partners, our sexual needs and desires may not align, which, whilst normal, can cause misunderstandings, resentment and frustration in a relationship,” says Anita. “If your needs aren’t aligning, then it can be helpful to talk to your partner, a trusted friend, a medical practitioner or health professional.”

Another factor that causes sex and intimacy issues when grieving is guilt. Ideally, having sex and being intimate with

someone makes us feel good, but sometimes this can leave us feeling guilty, leading to thoughts like “how can I enjoy myself when my loved one has died?” It is perfectly normal to feel this way. Try to keep in mind however, that happiness and sadness can often co-exist and that as well as pleasure, sex and intimacy can also provide comfort and connection.

New Relationships

Seeking out new relationships, whether with a new partner, new friends or even in a new workplace, is common after a death. Significant life events can often lead us to question what is missing in our lives and sometimes we may feel the people in our current relationships don’t understand us or aren’t able to give us what we need. Often people find it difficult to connect with others who may not have shared a similar experience and may find greater solace connecting with or attending a support group for others who have experienced a similar loss, e.g. the death of a parent or the death of a child. This can be a useful way of increasing your network, but keep in mind, that you don’t have to choose between old and new. You can have the best of both — preserving and working on existing relationships whilst forming new ones.

Communication

The key to any healthy relationship, regardless of whether it’s with a partner, family member, friend or colleague, is healthy communication.

We communicate not just by talking and listening, but also through our actions and body language, tone of voice, touch, and by being understanding. Try to keep in mind that some people find it difficult to talk about their grief and that this is okay. Not everyone is comfortable using words to express feelings, so you may need to try to find other ways that you can communicate with them. “Remember that we all have different ways of expressing grief and also of expressing support,” says Anita. “Writing a letter, doing something thoughtful or helpful, or even simply giving them a hug, are just some examples of how you can show someone that you are there for them and that you care.”

Seeking Help

If your grief is affecting your relationships, know that this can be a very natural and normal part of the grieving process, due to the pain being experienced. If it is becoming problematic, however, talking to someone about it, whether it is the person involved, a supportive friend/family member or a health professional is a good idea. Grief can be a particularly testing time for relationships, but with love, understanding and good communication, your relationships can survive and with time, may even become stronger.



Useful Resources

Relationships Australia
www.relationships.org.au

Letter From the Director



In this edition:

- Feature article: Grief and Relationships
- ACGB Support Group: Spanish-Speaking Bereavement Support Group
- Two new *Your Stories* contributions
- Featured grief resources

Welcome to the Spring 2014 edition of *The Rosemary Branch*.

In this edition, our feature article looks at grief and relationships. Although grief can be an intensely personal and private experience, it is also one that takes place in the context of our relationships with others. We know that the opportunity to receive support and care from those around us is vitally important as we deal with our loss. We also know however, that many of the problems bereaved people can have are social problems, e.g. the inability of others to understand and respond to the bereaved. This edition of *The Rosemary Branch* considers grief and relationships and explores how the way we deal with loss can impact upon our relationships with others.

Also in this edition, we've included two new 'Your Stories' contributions, information on our new Spanish-Speaking Bereavement Support Group, and a number of new bereavement resources that are available for purchase here at the Centre.

If you would like to add or remove yourself from this mailing list please email newsletters@grief.org.au or call (03) 9265 2100. If you would prefer to receive *The Rosemary Branch* via email, please remove yourself from our mailing list, then visit our website www.grief.org.au and click the Mailing List icon, to sign up.

Kind regards,

Chris Hall

Chief Executive Officer,
Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement

ACGB Support Groups

Support groups are a way of bringing people together in a safe space to share common life experiences. This column looks at the range of bereavement support groups offered by the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement, and how you might become involved.

Spanish-Speaking Bereavement Support Group

The Spanish-speaking community in Australia is broad and diverse, consisting of approximately 100,000 people — a number that is increasing day by day.

"Sometimes for various reasons, especially in difficult times, we need to be able to express our emotions and feelings in our own language,"

says Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement Specialist Bereavement Counsellor and Support Group Facilitator, Miguel Lopez.

"For this reason, the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement is organising a Spanish-speaking support group for people who are grieving following the death of a loved one".



To register your interest in this group, or for further information, please call 03 9265 2100 or email Miguel via m.lopez@grief.org.au

Grupo de Apoyo Hispano Parlante para Personas en Duelo

La comunidad de habla hispana en Australia es amplia y diversa. En la actualidad en su conjunto conforma cerca de 100.000 personas y este número se incrementa día a día.

"A veces por diversas razones, especialmente en los momentos difíciles, necesitamos expresar en nuestra propia lengua todas nuestras

emociones y sentimientos," señala el psicoterapeuta especializado en duelo y facilitador de grupos del Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement, Miguel López.

"The Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement, consciente de esta realidad, está organizando grupos de apoyo en español para personas que

están atravesando una situación de duelo debido al fallecimiento de un ser querido."



Si tiene alguna pregunta o desea participar no dude en contactarnos al 03 9265 2100 o escribanos a m.lopez@grief.org.au



Your Stories

Dear Mum, I See You

By Donna Petersen

I want you to know that I forgive you and that I hope you can forgive me too.

I want you to know that I am stronger than you think and all my hidden strength comes from you.

I want you to know you can rest in peace now, nobody can hurt you anymore.

I want you to know that you were in my thoughts every day you were alive and thereafter.

I hope that you are getting on with my brother, Eric.

I wish you could see me now, like I see you. I don't want to be here without you, you are my mum and I know you, I see you.

I was there with you in the darkness and although I was little and naïve, I did see you.

I want you to know all your triumphs will not go un-noticed because I live on and there's a part of you in Jade, a great part.

Jade was only 4 years old when you suddenly left this plain of earth but she will not forget what a loving, kind, caring paw paw she had in you.

I will try to treasure your life and show Jade all the amazing traits inherited from you, which continues to live on through her.

I see myself like you and for a long time it scared me, but now I see I was really afraid that I could not live up to your image. With each passing moment I am reminded of how much I miss you.

I hope you can understand why it was hard for me to see you in recent times and I could tell you desperately wanted to take more of me, but I want you to know after losing my brother, I really didn't think I had anymore to give. But through your death, I realised "we always have more to give... we simply need to believe in ourselves" and you gave this to me.

I hope you don't mind but to my brother, Eric, thank you for living your life so fully, there's not much you did not try,

experience and in your 43 years of life, you have done so much and whether or not you knew it at the time, your bucket list was full.

Brother, I want you to go easy on mum, she's not used to this, she's new but she's family. With each passing day, I know I am closer to seeing both of you and that lightens my heart a little.

Mum, don't worry about me, about Jade, about Tim, about anything. Just rest. Just relax, you have done better than your best and for that I am grateful.

Thank you for looking after me as best as you could. I know it was not easy and even though brother and you are gone, I do have faith that we will reunite and all those who stood in our way cannot touch us.

I love you mum, always have, always will.

Nothing Much Changes At My House

By Mim Markovic

The dust from a thousand solo dances lives on the mantelpiece

In places where the dust cloth doesn't reach
Tumbleweeds of dog hair gather and meet
Under the couch, multiplying every week.

Cobwebs wave me goodbye as I leave for work
And greet me when I return from my exercise class
Bills inevitably come in on Tuesday and I stick them on the fridge

Ritualistically I put the bins and recycling out every Wednesday.

I dream similar themes,
Night, after night, after night
Of trains, toilets, crowds and swimming
I am a psychoanalyst's delight.

The online dating sites offer the same old
Lonely hearts looking for meaningless sex
Whilst I search for meaningfulness in life.

Every day I think of my dead lover and wish
I could have coffee and talk with him again
Then I buy a new flat pack dining setting
And pretend I am an interior designer for an hour.

I find luxury Egyptian sheets (on special)
and change my bedding
And dream that I am kissing a good looking stranger
in the shower.

I join an online social group
Dress up, take a deep breath
And bravely go out on my own
To smile and meet new people.

Nothing much really
Changes at my house
The changes you see,
Happen inside me.

Slowly.

Your Stories is online!

To learn more about how you can contribute, or to read other people's contributions, go to www.grief.org.au and click on **Your Stories**.

Join with the Australian
Centre for Grief and
Bereavement
and help transform
the lives of
grieving people.



The Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement is a not for profit organisation and relies heavily on donations for the provision of services. Donations over \$2 are tax deductible

and help support a range of support services including bereavement counselling, support groups, newsletters, events, education and training.

How to make a donation

1. Fill in this donation slip and return to ACGB via post.
2. Visit www.grief.org.au and click "Make a donation".
3. Call us on 1800 642 066.

One off donation

Here is my gift of: ☐ \$25 ☐ \$50 ☐ \$100 ☐ \$200
☐ Other \$ _____ (min. \$2)

My cheque / money order payable to the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement is enclosed or, please debit my:

☐ Mastercard ☐ Visa

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Card number _____ / _____ / _____ / _____

Signature _____ Expiry ____ / ____

Regular contribution

☐ I will make a regular gift of \$ _____ (min. \$10)

I would like to make these payments:

- ☐ Every month ☐ Every 3 months
☐ Every 6 months ☐ Every 12 months

Contact details*

Name _____

Address _____

Suburb _____

State _____ Postcode _____

Email _____

Phone _____

☐ Please send me information about including a gift in my Will to the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement

Thank you

Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement

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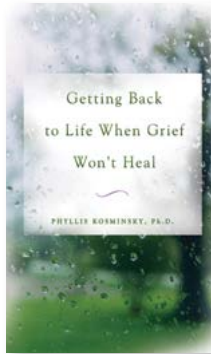
Email: info@grief.org.au

ABN: 22 038 903 478

www.grief.org.au

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Featured Resources



Getting Back to Life When Grief Won't Heal

Phyllis Kosminsky

\$22.95 (incl. GST)

Are you finding it hard to get over the loss of a loved one? Does it seem like you'll never move on with your life? Do you feel that you're stuck in the grieving process? You may be experiencing complicated mourning, the feeling of being 'stuck' in your sorrow, frustration, and unresolved

issues. This book provides a path through your grief with real inspiration, invaluable insight and deeply felt advice. You'll learn that, yes, there is hope and, with time, you can let go of the overwhelming sense of loss and embrace life.



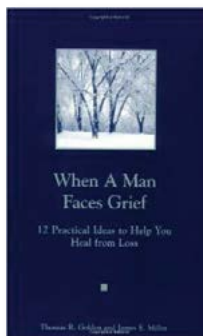
The Children Who Lived: Using Harry Potter and Other Fictional Characters to Help Grieving Children and Adolescents

Kathryn A. Markell & Marc A. Markell

\$56.95 (incl. GST)

Harry Potter's experiences of grief, as well as the grief experiences of other fictional characters, can be used by educators,

counsellors, and parents to help children and adolescents deal with their own grief and loss. *The Children Who Lived: Using Harry Potter and Other Fictional Characters to Help Grieving Children and Adolescents* uses classic tales and Harry Potter books to help grieving children and adolescents. A number of activities, discussion questions and games are included in the text and the companion CD.



When a Man Faces Grief / A Man You Know is Grieving

Thomas R. Golden & James E. Miller

\$14.95 (incl. GST)

This concise, informative guide is an innovative 'double book'. Half is for men as they grieve and the other half for those who want to understand the masculine style of grief and learn how to support men as they mourn.

These books, along with a range of other useful resources, can be purchased from the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement.



Visit www.grief.org.au/resources to download a resource guide/order form, email info@grief.org.au or call 1800 642 066.

CUT ALONG THIS DOTTED LINE





Our Services

The Rosemary Branch

For all enquiries about *The Rosemary Branch*, please contact the Centre on 03 9265 2100 or email newsletters@grief.org.au to subscribe to our mailing list. To download a PDF version of current and past editions, or to receive *The Rosemary Branch* as an e-newsletter, go to www.grief.org.au

Bereavement Counselling and Support Service

The Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement (ACGB) operates a statewide Specialist Bereavement Counselling and Support Service for Victoria. This program is funded by the Victorian Government Department of Health and has counsellors located across metropolitan Melbourne and in regional areas (Grampians, Gippsland, Hume, Barwon South-West, and Loddon Mallee). For further information, call 03 9265 2100, or email counselling@grief.org.au

Support Groups

ACGB operates a range of support groups, including groups for adults, children, bereaved partners, death of a parent and many more. For further information call 03 9265 2100, or email support@grief.org.au

Lending Library

The Lending Library is a portable collection of books about grief and loss. The books cover a wide range of topics and cater for all age groups. For more information, please contact the Centre on 03 9265 2100 or email counselling@grief.org.au

Volunteering

Would you like to contribute to the work of the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement as a volunteer? Contact us on 03 9265 2100, or email info@grief.org.au

Remembrance Events

Remembrance Events are held by the Centre during the year. Information is sent to clients of the Centre who are on our mailing list prior to the event. For further information call 03 9265 2100, or email counselling@grief.org.au

Better Health Channel



ACGB is a content partner with the Better Health Channel. Better Health Channel provides health and medical information that is quality assured, reliable, up to date, easy to understand, regularly reviewed and locally relevant. For more information, go to www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au

Healthshare



Healthshare is an Australian national health initiative designed to provide better access to health expertise and improve the quality of health information online. ACGB is a content provider within Healthshare's online bereavement support community. Users can post questions or share experiences with others. ACGB staff regularly answer questions posted by the community. For more information, go to www.healthshare.com.au

We value your feedback

If you have feedback about *The Rosemary Branch*, the Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement Counselling and Support Service, or any of the services we deliver, we would love to hear from you. Contact us on 03 9265 2100 or email info@grief.org.au



The Australian Centre for Grief and Bereavement acknowledges the support of the Victorian Government.

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